revenge on his mind.

In 2012, it was Majithia who helped turn this urban constituency into a Sidhu estate. The ex-cricketer was still with the BJP. His gynaecologist wife Navjot Kaur Sidhu won the seat with the help of Majithia, who comes from a family with a centuries-old imprint on the Majha region. Sidhu fell out with Majithia and his brother-in-law, Sukhbir Badal, soon after. A lot of water has flown down the Raavi since then. In the past six months, hostilities peaked as Sidhu practically made it a personal agenda to fix his former ally. It was on his insistence that an FIR was lodged and raids conducted on Majithia's properties in connection with alleged connections to drug trafficking and sand mafia operations.

That sets it up as the big battle of 2022, with ramifications across Punjab, especially in Majha—the land between rivers Raavi and Beas. Majha's four districts have 25 assembly seats. In 15 of them, the Akalis are in direct contest with the Congress. Amritsar East, bang in the middle, has Jat Sikhs and *savarna* Hindus in equal proportion as roughly two-thirds of its electorate. Dalits of both denominations make up the rest. The Akalis hope this high-voltage battle will charge up the cadre elsewhere. Last heard, Sidhu was off to Vaishno Devi—perhaps anticipating a move on the party's CM face. ■

TWEET

"You didn't include anything in the budget for Uttar Pradesh. But what was the need to insult the people of UP like this? Understand, the people of UP are proud to be 'UP type'. We're proud of the language, dialect, culture and history"

–PRIYANKA GANDHI, *National General Secretary, Congress*

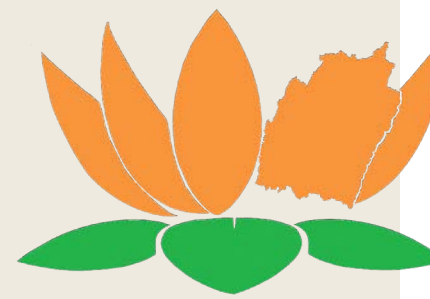
(Translated from the original Hindi response to Nirmala Sitharaman)

PARTY LINE: *BJP / MANIPUR*

ARJUNA WAS ELSEWHERE

Opinion polls, in their wisdom, have suggested an edge for the ruling BJP in Manipur. But fate is ensuring that the passage to that victory, if it comes, is paved with potholes—some perhaps even the size of constituencies. First, the saffron party lost its ally NPP, which has decided to go solo. The seat-sharing with NPF was less than smooth too. And almost incongruously, even Apna Dal (S), a BJP ally in Uttar Pradesh, has decided to field a candidate in Manipur! Then ticket distribution brought more than the usual quantum of chaos—the high number of aspirants first forced a delay, even as Congress and NPP released their first lists, and when the names did come out, near-riots broke out at party offices across the state.

Add to all this a touch of culture shock, courtesy RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat. Speaking at a book release in Imphal on January 24, Bhagwat said Manipur had been contributing to India's history since the Mahabharata. Social organisations are condemning the statement, saying it shows his ignorance about Manipur's history—because the Northeastern state has no relation to the eponymous kingdom named in the epic! Manipur may have voted saffron, but it's not exactly eager to be swallowed up in its cooptive narrative. ■



CANDIDATE WATCH: *ANTHONY MENEZES*

HOTEL CALANGUTE: THE WARM SMELL OF SORPOTEL



Anthony Menezes, a hotelier from Calangute, has seen some crazy twists and turns in his political career. Two decades ago, he had employed a young **Michael Lobo** as a waiter in his hotel. The street-smart Lobo gradually outgrew his master by a long country mile, becoming a Congress zilla panchayat member in 2005, then finding a propitious godfather in the late Manohar Parrikar and reaching the assembly twice on a BJP ticket. Meanwhile, Menezes too joined politics—a zilla panchayat victory came his way under Lobo's 'Together for Calangute' banner. Today, Lobo is the local Congress head honcho, and is eyeing a third straight win in Calangute. That essentially cut out Menezes, who had joined the Congress in 2020 and had fancied his own chances from the seat. Then his luck prevailed: a vacancy popped up in the TMC! Now, former employer and employee are pitted against each other. ■